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PPAL Shark Tank: Community – Develop a pharmacy technician training program

Description

Since the start of 2024, the Board of Pharmacies across America has accepted and enforced into their laws that pharmacy technicians are allowed to administer vaccines, not only in the case of an emergency. The majority of states have started implementing this new law, and since 01/01/2024, Oregon has begun to as well. Under the supervision of a licensed pharmacist, they can prepare and administer the vaccine to patients seven years and older or three years and older in the case of a state of emergency. According to BOP requirements, technicians authorized to vaccinate must have completed a training program accredited by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, the Accreditation Council for Pharmacy Education, or a similar health authority or professional body to prove competency in the administration of vaccines. Driving forces are possibly the improvement of vaccination rate, not to mention pharmacy wait times, and increased demand for Pharmacy technicians. By providing vaccination courses where our technicians become APhA certified, as we will coordinate our program with them, the technician who will go under our training will have the opportunity to work in any state with the ability to vaccinate. By staying up to date with current laws, we can improve quality of care and meet the needs within community pharmacies. Our program would enhance existing services and bring more profit to community pharmacies if more people began filling their prescriptions since they see that we are more efficient due to the staff. Our service would meet regulatory requirements and provide patient and company benefits.

While many factors are at work for what is causing a delay within pharmacies, vaccine appointments take time from the community pharmacists managing therapy, counseling, and making sure the patient's prescription is safe, effective, and accurate. This wait time especially increases during vaccine season when pharmacists need to stop what they are doing to prepare and administer vaccines to multiple appointments daily. Having more vaccine-certified technicians on the floor increases the productivity in pharmacies and improves workflow as they allow pharmacists to focus on other duties that impact how quickly a patient will have their prescription filled. On average, a patient spends 57 minutes waiting, some spend upwards to 2 hours, for the technicians to fill their script, the pharmacists to verify it, and for them to be counseled. Our service will provide technicians with the skills needed to aid our pharmacists in administering and reducing patients' waiting time and increasing customer satisfaction.

Our program will be located at all US Walgreens as we are aiming for national impact. By making it available nationally we can see an increase in technicians in our retail pharmacies that are more knowledgeable in updated laws. The increased demand for pharmacy technicians can be seen as a warning for all the pharmacy companies as it has been a cause of closure for small chains and independent pharmacies. With the help of this program, we are encouraging people to work more efficiently. Certified technicians who will go under immunization training can help with the workload in the pharmacy as there can be some particular shifts designated to immunization so other technicians and pharmacists can focus on filling prescriptions and counseling services. Overall, we can get more vaccine appointments covered throughout our day - especially during vaccine season- and increase the vaccination rate we currently see in our country.

Those who will benefit from our service are those enrolled in our pharmacy technician program and technicians who come and join our pharmacy staff who have not yet received their vaccination certificate. This service will reside within our human resources and onboarding

department, and in collaboration with APhA for our technicians to receive their education and certification.

The information available on the APhA website under Pharmacy-Based Immunization Administration by Pharmacy Technicians states it will be a 6 hours training program with a self-study component involving passing the self-study assessment with a grade of 70% or higher in 2 contact hours during the live seminar component, which involves attending the full live seminar, and successfully completing the injection technique assessment, and completing the online assessment and evaluation. Successful completion of this component will result in 4 contact hours and 4.0 continuing education credits. Upon successful completion of the program, participants will be provided with a certificate of completion in combination with the original certificate of completion. These certifications will be good for 3 years from the completion date of the refresher program as it is published on the APhA website.

Gap Analysis:

In conducting a gap analysis, it is essential to assess the existing landscape and identify areas where improvements or new services can be provided. Currently, in the pharmacy technician training industry, there is a growing demand for certified professionals, as evidenced by a steady increase in job opportunities, with a 5% growth in the market over the past two years. While Walgreens offers a tech program covering basic pharmaceuticals, calculations, medication, pharmacology, and communication skills, there are several competitors in the field, including PCC, Clark College, Charter College, RiteAid, Fred Meyer, Walmart, and Safeway.

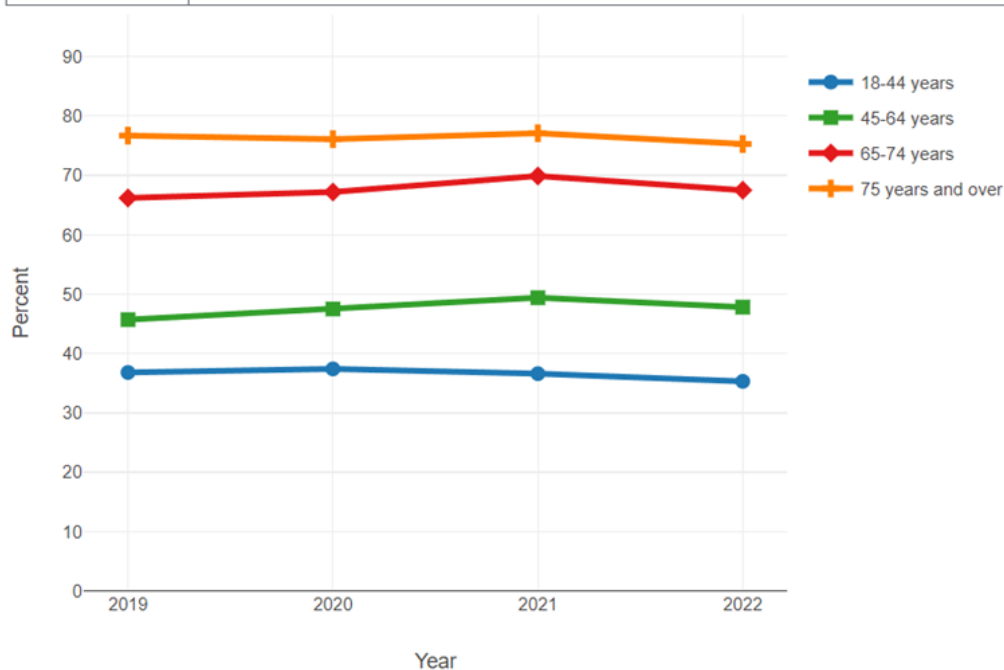
The need we aim to address is twofold: providing training for obtaining the national pharmacy technician certificate while accommodating full-time employment as a pharmacy assistant and addressing the growing demand for trained technicians, particularly in the area of immunizations. By offering ongoing, individualized training based on quarterly evaluations and allowing technicians to become certified, we anticipate several benefits. Firstly, productivity in the pharmacy will increase, especially during vaccination season, as trained technicians can administer vaccines while others focus on filling prescriptions. This will lead to reduced wait times and increased efficiency, as pharmacists will have more time for clinical tasks and patient counseling. Additionally, customers will receive vaccinations from knowledgeable and certified individuals, leading to higher satisfaction levels and trust-building relationships. Overall, our training program aims to enhance customer service quality, streamline operations, and provide additional benefits such as increased efficiency and improved patient care.

SWOT

Our business does a great job of certifying technicians and training them in basic duties like dose calculations and customer service. In addition, we can do this in a more timely manner than most of our competitors. The role of a technician is growing. More states are allowing technicians to continue administering vaccines; however, feedback shows that pharmacy technicians are not always extremely confident in their abilities. Previous studies have shown that technicians feel more satisfied with their jobs and feel like they contribute more to the pharmacy

when they can vaccinate. Thus, ensuring that more technicians can vaccinate will more than likely improve efficiency in the pharmacy.

Year	Receipt of influenza vaccination
2019	46.8
2020	47.9
2021	48.7
2022	47.2



The above figures, taken from the CDC, show that while flu vaccination rates were steadily increasing from 2019-2021, rates have started to drop again. This is an area that could be improved upon.

Advertisement

Establishing our goals helps gear our strategies for advertising. Thus, we would like to mention Walgreens's vision statement: "To be the first choice for health and daily living needs, serving our customers with the highest level of care and convenience." It is our utmost priority to create and implement programs that will help serve our customers and advance our employees' skills and knowledge in providing the best care possible. Promoting vaccination training among

pharmacy technicians will enhance Walgreen's commitment to public health and community well-being.

Our stakeholders:

- **Customer/Communities:** One of the most frequent complaints at any pharmacy is the wait times. For that reason, our patients are stakeholders as they will be the ones benefiting from the vaccination program. They will receive their vaccines in a more efficient, safe, and appropriate manner from our friendly pharmacy technicians.
- **Pharmacy Technicians:** As our primary target market, pharmacy technicians are one of the stakeholders because they are the ones learning and experiencing the program. They will benefit from enhanced skills, career opportunities, and job satisfaction. By completing the vaccination program, they will be better equipped to provide immunization with the supervision of our pharmacists.
- **Pharmacists:** The last line of defense before vaccination verification is approved and administered. Pharmacists play a crucial role in educating and supervising our pharmacy technicians to provide quality care while immunizing a patient. The pharmacist will also benefit from this program as it will relieve the burden of being the only staff who can vaccinate.
- **Walgreens Corporate Leadership:** They play a role in setting the path and direction of the company. They are responsible for providing resources, implementing policies, and hiring/training their employees, which includes vaccination training for pharmacy technicians.
- **Oregon Board of Pharmacy:** They are responsible for setting standards and guidelines for pharmacy practice. Effective 1/1/2024, the Oregon Board of Pharmacy approved certified pharmacy technicians to vaccinate under the supervision of a pharmacist. They will oversee maintaining the licensure and accreditation status of our pharmacy technicians.

Advertisement approach:

- **Print advertisements:** These will come in flyers and memorandums. Flyers can be posted on the bulletin boards of each pharmacy breakroom. Memorandums will be sent out to all pharmacy employees to announce the establishment of the program.
- **Online advertisements:** These will come in the form of social media postings, email newsletters, and banners. Social media will include Instagram, Facebook, and X (formerly known as Twitter). Email newsletters will be sent to all customers to inform them of lower waiting times to receive vaccinations. Banners will be posted on our website for customers and employees to view.
- **Incentive programs:** These will come in the form of bonuses, recognition awards, and professional development opportunities to incentivize pharmacy technicians to complete the vaccination program.

Financial Analysis

Start-up costs must take into account development of the training module, certification through an accredited body, and possible accreditation in the future. Typical immunization training

requirements include 2 hours of self study, which can be done via an eLearning module and 4 hours of live training, including immunization technique checkoffs and a final exam. Average cost to develop 1 hour of an eLearning program is around \$10,000, so the cost for a 2 hour training module would be around \$20,000. This module would need to be updated and maintained as time goes on and new recommendations and guidelines are put in place. Through APhA, non-member price for the immunization certificate needed to be authorized to give vaccines is \$345 per person and it expires after 3 years. Eventually, it would be wise to develop our own accredited program but because of significant costs associated with accreditation, this is a good starting point. The largest costs associated with start-up would be development of the program itself and profit associated with both technician and pharmacist time on the clock. The technician will need to spend time on the clock completing this program rather than performing other duties, and the pharmacist will need to check off the immunization technique on the clock as well. This time away from other work will be a cost in productivity. Physical supplies will not be an issue though since we already stock immunization supplies and have employee training computer stations. Costs of the program will rise over time as technician wages rise and updates are added to guidelines and recommendations.

Human Resources and Policies

The successful implementation of the new program relies heavily on robust support from the Human Resources department across various facets. Firstly, HR's involvement is pivotal in streamlining recruitment, hiring, and onboarding processes to ensure alignment with the specific needs of the service. This involves not only identifying suitable candidates but also facilitating their seamless integration into the organization.

In terms of personnel requirements, a comprehensive understanding of the roles, duties, qualifications, and full-time equivalents (FTEs) needed is essential. For instance, the oversight of training modules and immunization certification for pharmacy technicians falls under the purview of the HR store and pharmacy manager. Collaboration with relevant bodies, such as the American Pharmacists Association (APhA), is crucial for incorporating pertinent modules, like the "Pharmacy-Based Immunization Administration By Pharmacy Technicians," into the training regimen.

Recruitment strategies must be carefully crafted to attract candidates who possess the requisite skills and commitment to fulfill the demands of the program. This could entail proactive engagement with potential candidates at career fairs and other networking events, with pharmacy managers playing a key role in articulating the program's value proposition.

Regarding personnel, decisions need to be made about whether existing staff can be upskilled to meet the program requirements or if new hires are necessary. If the latter, HR must assess the availability of suitable candidates in the job market and devise strategies to attract them to the organization. Additionally, considerations must be given to providing opportunities for existing technicians to obtain necessary certifications, ensuring inclusivity and career progression within the company.

Policies form the backbone of any program, and HR will be instrumental in their development. This includes delineating the structure, requirements, and assessment criteria of the training program, as well as ensuring compliance with guidelines from authoritative bodies like APhA and

the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC). Clear delineation of roles and responsibilities for pharmacy technicians, pharmacists, and other healthcare providers within the organization is also crucial, along with establishing qualifications and certifications required for each role.

In summary, HR's role extends beyond mere administrative functions; it serves as a strategic partner in laying the foundation for the program's success. Through careful planning, collaboration, and policy development, HR can ensure that the organization is equipped with the necessary human capital to deliver high-quality services while adhering to regulatory standards and best practices in the field.

Metrics, Productivity and CQI

To assess the success of our vaccination program, we identified the key performance indicators that reflect relevant, meaningful, and quantified data, information that helps us take action, and provide a platform for improvement:

1. **Vaccination Output:**
 - a. **Data collection:** The number of vaccinations administered per day/week/month.
 - b. **Target:** Our initial goal will depend on multiple factors, such as the pharmacy's size, number of hires, and expected customer demands.
2. **Customer Satisfaction:**
 - a. **Data collection:** Measured through surveys, feedback forms, and online reviews
 - b. **Target:** Achieve a minimum satisfaction rating of 90%.
3. **Error Rate:**
 - a. **Data collection:** Measured through the rate of adverse events due to incorrect vaccine administration by the pharmacy technicians, incorrect vaccine given, or improper documentation. The values used to calculate the error rate will be self-reported.
 - b. **Target:** maintain an error rate of less than 1%
4. **Technician Training and Certification:**
 - a. **Data collection:** Measure the number of pharmacy technicians who complete the vaccination and certification.
 - b. **Target:** 100% participation and completion amongst all pharmacy technicians prior to program initiation.
5. **Revenue and Cost Analysis:**
 - a. **Data collection:** Generate profit and loss reports to ensure program operation costs do not exceed revenue.
 - b. **Target:** Net positive return on investment within the first six months of program initiation.

Productivity Measures

To maximize output, key productivity measures include:

1. **Resource Utilization:** Maintain records of all materials used to ensure waste is minimized. These materials include:
 - a. Vaccines
 - b. Syringes
 - c. Needles
 - d. Sharps disposal
 - e. PPEs (personal protective equipment)
 - f. Alcohol swabs
2. **Staff Scheduling:** Optimize staff distribution to meet customers' needs while ensuring reasonable work hours for staff members.
3. **Process Optimization:** Appropriate labor allocation to streamline patient processing, vaccination, and post-vaccination observations, with the overall goal of wait time reduction.

Continuous Quality Improvement

Since we are implementing a pilot test for the vaccination program and monitoring metrics and data, we are adopting the IHI Model for Improvement to refine and enhance the program and vaccination process. Our model will follow the PDSA (plan, do, study, and act) cycle:

1. **Plan:** Implement the online vaccination program service available to employed pharmacy technicians.
2. **Do:** Execute the plan to select stores.
3. **Study:** Collect customer and pharmacy technician feedback, and quantitative data (efficiency, number of vaccinations, etc.).
4. **Act:** Based on the results, either expand the vaccination program to other stores or further refine the program in currently selected locations.

Legal/Regulatory Issues

Across the United States, pharmacy technicians are being given the right to vaccinate. To provide a consensus of this law across different BOPs, we use Oregon state's Board of Pharmacy definition from OAR 855-125-0305 (Services: Vaccine Administration). A certified Oregon pharmacy technician or pharmacy technician may perform the act of administering vaccines under a qualified pharmacist's supervision to patients seven years or older. They are also able to vaccinate persons from the age of three years and up during a state of public health emergency declared by the governor or during a disease outbreak declared by the public health director. They must receive training that includes infection control, recognition of anatomical landmarks, competency in hand-on administration technique, as well as have an active CPR certification from either the AHA or American Red Cross (or any other equivalent program) prior to being able to administer vaccines. Programs they may enroll in for the training required should be either approved by the ACPE, curriculum-based programs from an ACPE-accredited college or school of pharmacy or state or local health department programs; by an appropriately qualified practitioner, or programs approved by the board. Technicians should then be able to document the vaccine administration, what was given, the dose, expiration date, lot number, and injection site, and notify their supervising pharmacist at once if they suspect a patient is having an adverse

reaction to a vaccine. Records and forms must then be filed in the pharmacy and readily available to the board upon request and must be retained for three years. To qualify, technicians must be at least eighteen years of age and have earned a high school diploma or equivalent. Alongside completing this vaccine training program, the technician-to-be must then finish the rest of their accredited pharmacy technician training program and apprenticeship provided by Walgreens and must pass the Pharmacy Technician Certification Exam (PTCE) to be allowed to provide vaccination services. This is a general overview of what the BOP allows for pharmacy technicians, but this program will adhere to each state BOP's rules and regulations concerning pharmacy technician services within our Walgreens program.

Accredited via APhA and taught by a Board and APhA immunization certified clinical pharmacist employee from Walgreens. The American Pharmacists Association is accredited by the Accreditation Council for Pharmacy Education as a provider of continuing pharmacy education. The Pharmacy-Based Immunization Administration by Pharmacy Technicians training program is approved for a total of 6.0 contact hours of continuing pharmacy education credits. Technicians participating in this training program will need to create a valid APhA username and password, as well as a CPE Monitor account to claim credit if they are already certified technicians applying to our program. According to the APhA website, "Successful completion of the self-study component involves passing the self-study assessment with a grade of 70% or higher and will result in 2 contact hours of CPE credit... [and] successful completion of the live seminar component involves attending the full live seminar, successfully completing the injection technique assessment, and completing the online assessment and evaluation... [which] result in 4 contact hours of CPE credit." Students will be provided with two opportunities to successfully complete the program assessment. After technicians complete the online self-study component of the APhA "Pharmacy-Based Immunization Administration By Pharmacy Technicians" provided, we will have our stores' pharmacist manager teach the live seminar portion that teaches hands-on immunization techniques and sign off on the certificates. In the occasion that a pharmacy manager is unable to conduct the live seminar portion, we will always have two staff board-certified pharmacists prepared and able to perform the duty to ensure technicians perform properly and successfully. The Certificate of Achievement will be available online upon successfully completing the necessary activity requirements, and their certificate will show that they are APhA-approved to vaccinate anywhere in the states according to each state's pharmacy technician vaccination laws and regulations, and therefore also each state's Walgreens policies and procedures. It will expire 3 years from the date of issue and will be the immunizing technician's responsibility to remain up to date with continuing professional development and education to renew their certificate.

Conclusion

It is necessary, as immunizations are the future of pharmacy. Including technicians in providing these services, we are providing more access to vaccinations, reducing wait times, and providing pharmacists more time in the pharmacy to complete their clinical duties and keep patients happy in the store. This will especially be useful during flu season when everyone is coming in to get their shots and the pharmacy falls behind schedule. By having technicians who are well-versed in preparing, administering, and documenting vaccinations- specifically flu vaccines- they have the pharmacists' and patients' trust to provide critical patient services during a stereotypically hectic environment.

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